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Destination Management

An Analytical Evaluation of the Strategic Role of DMOs in Sustainable Global and Regional Tourism Development

The travel and tourism sector is expected to generate US$12 trillion to the global economy in 2026, representing 9.9 per cent of global GDP, and employing 376 million people, which is about one in every nine globally (WTTC, 2026). In 2025, international arrivals also set a new record with 1.52 billion (UN Tourism, 2025). However, the sector's size is now matched by the obvious fragility. The first half of 2026 saw arrivals rise by just 0.4 per cent, due to a decline in arrivals to the Middle East, which fell by 22 per cent, and increased fuel and travel costs, while UN Tourism revised its annual growth projection down from 3–4 per cent to 1–2 per cent (Hospitalitynet, 2026). They come on the heels of the travel downturn caused by COVID-19 and amid protests from residents against what they consider 'overtourism' and the increasing threat of physical climate change. In this context, growth on its own is no longer accepted as evidence of success. Who benefits, who loses, and who bears the responsibility for the compromises are becoming more salient questions.

Generally, it is the role of destination management organisations (DMOs) to respond to that question. According to Morrison (2023), a DMO is the institution which is responsible for coordinating, planning and marketing a destination for its various stakeholders. Pike and Page (2014) trace the evolution of terminology from destination marketing organisations to destination management organisations, which should focus more on product development, visitor management, and sustainability. There are different levels of DMOs: national (VisitBritain), regional or city (Wonderful Copenhagen) and local partnerships. They are also delivered in different institutions and formats, such as government departments, private membership associations and public–private partnerships, and each institution has different funding and accountability. The real problem is that the rebranding has seldom provided additional powers or budgets. Some "management" organisations still have a very narrow remit, limited to marketing, while others remain reliant on funders who evaluate them based on visitor numbers (Pike and Page, 2014; Gutic, 2022).

It is the position of this essay that, in general, DMOs are supposed to catalyse sustainable tourism development, but in fact they have influence, not authority. As such, their effectiveness is not entirely dependent on marketing skills, but on their governance model, how they are funded and their capacity to bring stakeholders with power to the table. The argument is made in four phases. It first evaluates tourism as a strategic asset from an economic, social and environmental perspective. It then explores the

respective models of the main destinations and reviews the concept of destination development management, followed by a discussion of destination management leadership in destination planning and a discussion of emerging challenges and recommendations. Examples of cases are taken from Europe (Venice, Copenhagen, Amsterdam, Blackpool), Asia and the Gulf (Bhutan, Saudi Arabia and Dubai) and a developing regional destination (northern Pakistan). Supporting figures and tables are in the appendices.

Tourism's strategic value is best measured using the Triple Bottom Line (TBL), where performance is measured in economic, social and environmental outcomes and not just in terms of profit (Elkington and Rowlands, 1997). A second lens is added to the stakeholder theory. The organisation should not only consider the groups that provide funding, but all groups that may be impacted by or impact the organisation (Kivits and Sawang, 2021). Those groups are: residents, businesses, local and national government, and visitors, and they often have conflicting interests for the DMO. The TBL has one problem, however. The three dimensions being presented as a balance suggests that sacrificing the environment in exchange for economic benefits is acceptable. Strong-sustainability viewpoints, however, do not accept this trade-off, and view ecological boundaries as limits that are not amenable to trade. (Buckley, 2012) This difference can be important for DMOs. The word "balance" in the definition is the key to determining the nature of sustainability, whether it is a constraint on growth or a label attached to growth, as a DMO defines it.

The economic argument for tourism is strong. The sector generates foreign exchange and work opportunities at low capital cost. Multiplying effects also help to circulate visitor spending through local supply chains, both direct and indirect, and induced. Small island developing states have the highest level of dependence. Tourism is the primary contributor to GDP, foreign earnings and government revenue for the Maldives, and is always identified as the most tourism-dependent country in the world for the Caribbean (WTTC, 2026). There are three significant ways that DMOs add to this value. They bring to the developer and airline market the information and branding of a market to entice investors to invest in the destination. They are the ones who bid for and organise the events, especially those that have business associated with them, that attract high-spending visitors away from peak hours. They also conduct campaigns during the shoulder season and regionally to distribute demand throughout the year and off the peak centres. If these functions are successful, tourism is not a mere earner of income for a few hot spots, but it is also a tool to promote regional development.

The economic advantages are not as solid as the claims. Imported goods, foreign ownership and international intermediaries are significant ways in which a sizable proportion of revenue is lost from the

local economy in many developing and island destinations (Mowforth and Munt, 2015). Tourism jobs tend to be seasonal, poorly paid, insecure and have low status, as was the case with employment (Baum, 2015). Tourism monoculture is extremely vulnerable to shocks if it displaces other sectors. COVID-19 starkly highlighted this vulnerability as destinations that depended on tourism were losing income within a matter of days (Gössling, Scott and Hall, 2020). The DMO's own metrics are part of the problem. Most DMOs report success in terms of arrivals, bed-nights and spending and those metrics are rewarded by funders. This is what it looks like to be successful. Instead, "value over volume" methods like Bhutan's traditional "high value, low volume" policy are based on the results of each visitor. These are still the occasional methods used.

From the social point of view, tourism has the potential to reinforce communities. Spending by visitors brings funds to heritage conservation and cultural events. It can also help to revitalise crafts and traditions that may otherwise be lost, and it can encourage a sense of pride in the local community. The price tag is becoming more evident in more established cities, however. Cultures can be commercialised and put on display for tourists. The gentrification of tourism creates the displacement of old residents from the historic centres and an increase in the prices of houses (Cocola-Gant, 2018). Barcelona has had numerous protests by locals and is seeking to remove the city's licensed tourist apartments by 2028. The city of Lisbon has limited the number of new short-term rental licenses in the historic centre of the city. In the historic centre of the city, the number of new short-term rentals is also limited in the city of Lisbon. This decline in resident attitudes is due to the phenomenon described by Doxey, G.V. (1975), Irridex. It moves from euphoria to apathy, irritation, and finally antagonism as tourism grows (see Appendix B). The mechanism is provided by social exchange theory: residents support tourism when they see the benefits as being greater than the costs; they withdraw their support when they do not (Ap, 1992). The implication is obvious for DMOs. Consent is a resource which can be exhausted, and a DMO which markets the destination without being involved in its use will run the risk of exhausting it.

The environmental dimension imposes the toughest constraints. Tourism is responsible for approximately 8 per cent of GHGs, and aviation is the biggest contributor to these emissions (Lenzen et al., 2018). Tourism also strains water resources, waste management and sensitive ecosystems, sometimes in the most vulnerable areas. In some cases, pricing is a way to manage the environment. Bhutan has reduced its Sustainable Development Fee from US200$toUS$100 per night in 2023, and the money is being used for conservation and public services (Reuters, 2023). Nationally, from parks to marine reserves, protected areas employ permit limits and entry restrictions. Such limits as carrying capacity are more difficult to

apply than they may seem. It is difficult to justify the impact of one visitor, since the impact depends on behaviour, timing, infrastructure and management as well as on the number of visitors (McCool and Lime, 2001). The Limits of Acceptable Change framework is a solution. In contrast to a ceiling, it sets standards a community will accept and tracks indicators against those standards (Stankey et al., 1985). It is more appropriate for the DMO, which likely does not have control over access but may have the ability to coordinate access monitoring.

The way that these dimensions are balanced in a DMO is largely dependent on the structure of the DMO itself. In 2017, Wonderful Copenhagen, a non-profit foundation supported by public institutions, declared "the end of tourism as we know it" and started to embrace a "localhood" approach where the quality of life of the residents is used as a proxy to assess the success of tourism (Copenhagen, 2017). In contrast, DMOs that have hotel occupancy taxes or membership fees are more likely to focus on growth, as revenue increases with overnight stays. The government is responsible for Dubai's tourism authority, which aims for concrete growth targets for visitors (see Appendix D, Table 1). The DMO's intentions are not the balancing element in the conclusion for this section. Who supports the DMO and what they view as success determines it.

When the balance between the three dimensions changes over time, DMOs must find a way to identify where a destination is and know what it will be like in the future. This is provided by destination development models. The models below are evaluated on two criteria: conceptual validity (i.e. does the model account for how destinations actually change) and practical usefulness (i.e. does the model help a DMO with limited power to decide what to do).

The most influential model is that of Butler's (1980) Tourism Area Life Cycle (TALC). It suggests destinations move through the stages of exploration, involvement, development, stagnation and consolidation. They then either decline or are rejuvenated. The graph is an S-curve of the number of visitors. Growth eventually outstrips the environment, infrastructure and community of the destination, leading to a fall in quality which reduces demand. Blackpool is an exceptionally good example. It was the most popular mass seaside resort in the mid-twentieth century in Britain. It was in a prolonged decline from the 1970s due to the loss of the tourism market to Spain for cheaper package holidays. It has since tried to regenerate itself with the support of regeneration funding, events and heritage attractions like the Showtown museum. This is mirrored in the Spanish costas, where resorts including Benidorm are focusing more on year-round demand and improved hotel standards, rather than low-cost high volume. Stagnation is the theme of Venice. While demand has not dropped, the number of tourists has surpassed

the social capacity of the historic centre, and the resident population there was below 50,000 in 2022. These are plotted on the TALC curve in Appendix A.

The shortcomings of TALC are well known. Haywood (1986) demonstrated that stages are difficult to detect unless after they have already occurred. Often the data required to find a point on the curve is not available and turning points are only apparent once they are already calculated. The model is also deterministic in the sense that it means that without managerial actions, there would be a decline. It makes the assumption of one product (a seaside resort) rather than a city with multiple products in the system, like London or Copenhagen, where the various components are in various stages at any given time. Most importantly for this period, TALC considers change as an endogenous change. It does not tolerate external shocks like COVID-19, war or extreme heat, which can cause a destination to go from growth to collapse in a matter of weeks. Restructuring, not just one rejuvenation, is a more apt description of the response of mature resorts, adds Agarwal (2002). Despite this, the model is still useful as a practical tool. The central theme, communicating the need to take steps to overcome capacity issues before they become stagnation, invites DMOs to take action early by diversification, investment and visitor management.

Plog's (1974) psychographic model also helps to explain who visits at each stage, complementing TALC. Allocentric travellers are looking for the new and finding new places. The rest of the midcentrics follow once the destination is known and available. The last are the Psychocentrics who look for familiarity and comfort. The demand side of the TALC curve can be explained by the fact that as a destination gets more developed, it becomes more attractive to the cautious visitors, and less so to the adventurous ones. The basis of the model is weak, however. It was created from data on U.S. surveys from the early 1970s, and subsequent efforts to replicate it have yielded mixed results (Litvin, 2006). Nowadays, the market is divided, and travellers are allocentric on one trip and psychocentric on the other due to the influence of social media. Plog's model is more of an explanatory pattern or reminder that the visitors of a destination will change as it becomes more popular with more people, rather than a segmentation approach.

The model of destination competitiveness and sustainability developed by Ritchie and Crouch (2003) is more detailed (see Appendix C). It identifies core resources and attractors, like the climate, culture, events, etc. It includes supporting factors and resources (including infrastructure, accessibility) and destination policy, planning and development. Everything else is based on the destination's marketing, and the stewardship of its quality and resources, and its qualifying and amplifying determinants (which include safety, cost, etc.). The logic of the model is illustrated in Saudi Arabia's Vision 2030. The state has invested in its core attractors (AlUla and the Red Sea coast) as well as supporting infrastructure (such as

new airports and visa liberalisation). The Ministry of Tourism and the Saudi Tourism Authority are responsible for ensuring the planning, development and marketing of the service. The breadth of the model, however, is its major drawback. It's difficult to measure, has no clear weighting, and is more difficult to break down into priorities; later work has sought to make it more operational (Dwyer and Kim, 2003). It can also have a competitiveness focus that can clash with sustainability. While Ritchie and Crouch (2003) make sustainability a part of the model, a destination can get "more competitive" by getting more visitors at the expense of residents and ecosystems.

To what extent do these models assist in the responses to the challenges outlined in Part 2? They can help in diagnosis. TALC indicates where capacity will be a problem, Plog indicates how the visitor mix will shift, and Ritchie and Crouch (2003) both indicate which performance levers will have an effect. All three are from a growth mindset that prioritises more visitors. None specifically reference leakage, wellbeing of residents, or carbon. Newer frameworks try to fill this missing piece. Regenerative tourism is about more than just minimising harm; it is a question of how tourism can be a force that benefits places and communities (Bellato, Frantzeskaki and Nygaard, 2022). In 2024, the UN Statistical Commission accepted the Statistical Framework for Measuring the Sustainability of Tourism by UN Tourism, which includes indicators for measuring the progress towards such goals. The answer is that classic models identify problems but don't provide enough information to take action. DMOs need to combine them, using TALC and Plog for anticipation, Ritchie and Crouch (2003) for structure, and sustainability indicators for direction.

In a model-driven diagnosis environment, leadership is necessary somewhere other than models. That leadership is through governance. Planning a destination is not a technical task that can be completed by one agency but rather a collaborative governance activity (Bramwell and Lane, 2011). Local tourism policy is a product of the interplay of relationships, trust and resources among a network of public and private actors as described by Dredge (2006). Beritelli, Bieger and Laesser (2007) also state that destinations are more like loosely coupled communities than firms. No one can assert themselves over the others. The structural reality of the essay's argument. The vast majority of DMOs have no power to zone, raise taxes, license businesses or regulate behaviour. The government holds that power, both at the national and local levels. DMOs thus act as conveners, creators of data and motivators to action. Volgger and Pechlaner (2014) conclude that networking ability is essential for DMO success, as is gaining acceptance among stakeholders as the DMO's coordinator, which provides them with legitimacy.

The position is most clearly illustrated by infrastructure. The number of visitors a destination can absorb is defined by airports, roads, public transport, digital connectivity, water and waste systems. However, DMOs typically push for these investments and don't actually provide them. The differences between state-led and fragmented models are enormous. In Saudi Arabia, the state, through the Public Investment Fund and developers such as Red Sea Global, has built airports and resorts from scratch. It has slapped them with clear restrictions, including a one-million-per-year cap on the number of visitors to the Red Sea resort. In northern Pakistan, the 18th Constitutional Amendment was introduced in 2010, and the responsibility of tourism is divided between federal and provincial authorities. Domestic tourist growth has significantly outpaced the growth of roads, parking and waste collection and sewage disposal in, for example, Murree, Naran and Hunza. The aftermath in January 2022 was heart-wrenching when more than 20 people lost their lives while stuck in cars in Murree when the hill station was buried under snow. An infrastructure side effect is that it also has strategic drawbacks. Infrastructure-led growth can quicken a destination's progress along the TALC curve. Increasing road and airport development increases the number of visitors at a rate that outstrips social and environmental capacity, leading to stagnation unless accompanied by capacity planning.

Another area of leadership that is limited is workforce capacity. COVID-19 has caused significant staff attrition in the hospitality and tourism industry, with those who were furloughed or laid off being transferred to other industries (Baum et al., 2020). The sector is consistently regarded as being low-paid, working unsocial hours and offering limited progression (Baum, 2015), and this makes recruitment and retention challenging. DMOs can support by facilitating employer-college and university partnerships, encouraging tourism careers, and organising skills programmes. This initiative is part of Saudi Arabia's Tourism Trailblazers (TT) program, which was established in 2021 to provide training for Saudi nationals in the tourism sector. In the UK, DMOs have yet to directly engage with skills, with the focus being on national tourism recovery planning and industry bodies. The biggest constraint is that the DMOs have virtually no control over wages, contracts or working conditions, which are determined by employers and labour law. They can enhance training; they cannot guarantee decent jobs in tourism. Hence the social aspect of sustainability is somewhat under their control.

The applications that DMOs have tested most clearly in the field of environmental conservation are visitor management applications. The applications in which DMOs have been testing to date most clearly are visitor management applications. The toolkit comprises caps, access fees and tourist taxes, timed entry, dispersal campaigns and demarketing (Mogelhoj, 2021). Venice implemented a day tripper access fee in

2024. By 2026, it was being applied on 60 days of the year at € 5- € 10, and it had sold nearly 680,000 tickets, so the city is looking to increase it to €30, as it believes the current rate will not deter anyone (Koumelis, 2026). Amsterdam has implemented Europe's highest tourist tax coupled with demarketing, such as their current 2023 ‘Stay Away’ campaign targeting young British men looking for nightlife. These measures bring two issues to the fore. First of all, they displace rather than decrease pressure. Visitors who are turned off by one day, district or city will go elsewhere. Second, they raise issues of justice. Access is priced, excluding less affluent visitors, and overnight visitors and residents are welcome. Both also rely on local authority powers. The second example concerns the lack of authority that most DMOs have in effective visitor management: that's Venice and Amsterdam – through city government.

Innovation can be a tool that DMOs can use to change behaviour without the need for regulation. Smart tourism relies on live data collected from sensors, mobile networks and bookings to track visitor flows and guide them (Gretzel et al., 2015). The CopenPay pilot began in Copenhagen in 2024, offering free meals, tours and entry to museums to anyone who visited the city using either a cycle or public transport, or collected litter. Itinerary labelling and certification systems that meet the GS-TC requirements seek to bring sustainable choices to the fore. But these practices have definite boundaries. It is easy to make environment-related claims without actual measurable change that occurs, making sustainability marketing greenwashing (Font and McCabe, 2017). There are many innovations that are still small pilots with positive publicity without changing the whole system, which is still based on long-haul flights and volume targets.

These four areas can be seen as following a pattern when combined. Persuasion and partnership are all that's needed for DMOs to be most effective as convenors, brokers and holders of data. They work best when change is needed with the authority to land, infrastructure, pay, and access. The recommendations hereafter seek to fill that yawning chasm between influence and authority.

The influence and authority of DMOs is widened by three emerging challenges. The first is of a geopolitical nature. Demand today is not only influenced by marketing, but also by conflict, by sanctions and by flight disruptions caused by changing visa policies. The war in the Middle East in 2026 reduced arrivals to the region by over 20% and temperature growth in the world (Hospitalitynet, 2026). With volatile conditions being the norm, TALC's lack of focus on external shocks is now revealed. The second challenge is technological. Between visitors and destinations are OTAs, metasearch sites and even the then-new AI-powered search and trip planning. They have disrupted the DMO's traditional role as an authoritative source of information, and the data on visitor behaviour are not DMO property. This

undermines one of the limited tools, information, with which DMOs have influence: data. The third one is climate. Mediterranean summers are changing due to extreme heat, wildfire and drought. Warm summer weather, coupled with a 6 per cent drop in arrivals in June 2026, was a reason for the decrease in Western Europe (CAPA, 2026). Climate change is also impacting seasons and placing locations at risk of physical risk (Scott, Hall and Gössling, 2019). Meanwhile, decarbonising aviation poses a risk to many of the long-distance markets that underpin developing destinations. Most DMOs do not have the capabilities to provide the crisis coordination, data infrastructure and adaptation planning that are required to meet each challenge.

Based on this analysis, the following recommendations are put forth. First, DMO funding and performance metrics should move away from the arrival/outlay measures to value, resident wellbeing and carbon intensity. As Part 2 demonstrated, the TBL is not meaningful unless funders pay for results beyond volume. The indicators are provided based on the sustainability framework of UN Tourism, which can be used immediately. Second, there needs to be a formal place for residents in destination governance, for instance in Councils or on the DMO's boards. Doxey's Irridex and Copenhagen's localhood strategy both point out the need to maintain, rather than assume, resident consent. Thirdly, DMOs need to develop data capability and establish data sharing agreements with platforms, mobile operators and booking intermediaries. This would make smart tourism more of a daily management task, thus in some way mitigating the loss of information control to tech companies. Fourth, governments should provide DMOs with explicit climate adaptation/ crisis resilience responsibilities and resources, such as scenario planning and coordinated crisis communication. This fills TALC's missing piece on shocks and acknowledges that recovery planning following COVID-19 has often been "growth at all costs" as well (Gutic, 2022). Fifth, additional investment in local capacity – skills, local supply chains and community ownership – is required for regional & developing destinations like northern Pakistan and the Caribbean, to ensure that more spending stays in the destination and leakage is reduced. Each recommendation is linked to the challenge it is addressing, the evidence and the stakeholder.

In summary, while DMOs play a crucial strategic role in sustainable tourism development, they face a major structural constraint. This is the only type of organisation capable of bringing together all the stakeholders that make decisions regarding a destination, yet most of them do not have the mandate and the resources needed to make anything happen from these consultations.

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Appendices

Appendix A, Figure 1: Tourism Area Life Cycle with case destinations

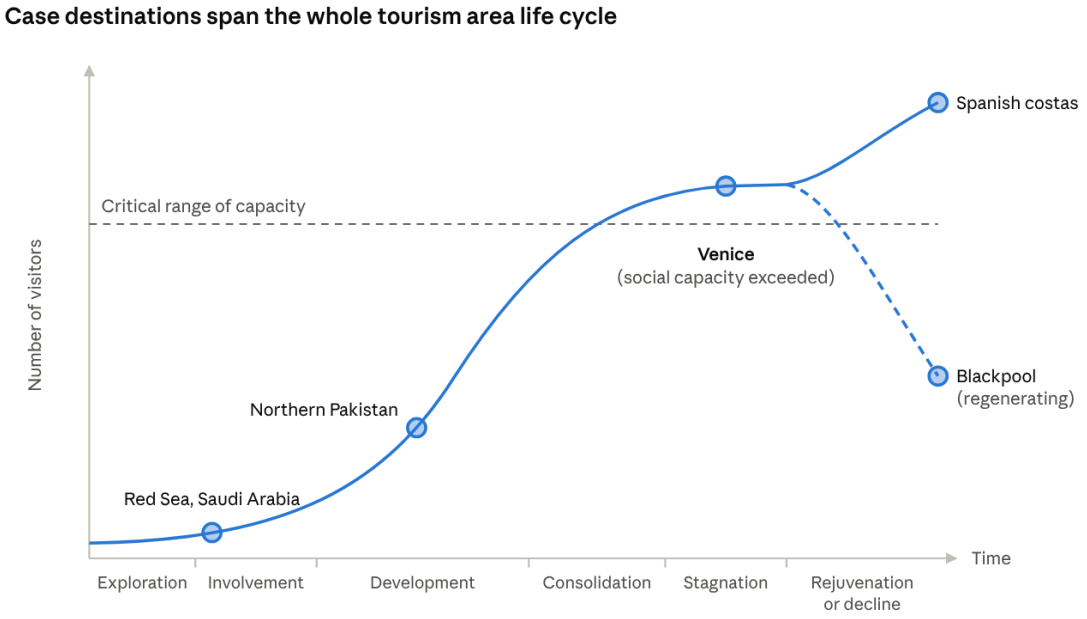


Figure 1 · Tourism Area Life Cycle with case destinations

Source: adapted from Butler (1980). Positions are the author's interpretation of the evidence discussed in Parts 3 and 4.

Appendix B, Figure 2: Doxey's Irridex

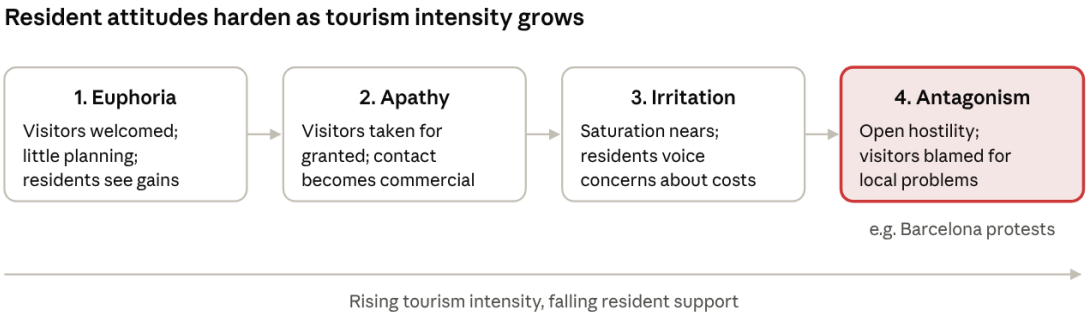


Figure 2 · Doxey's Irridex, four stages

Source: adapted from Doxey, G.V (1975).

Appendix C, Figure 3: Ritchie and Crouch's model of destination competitiveness, simplified

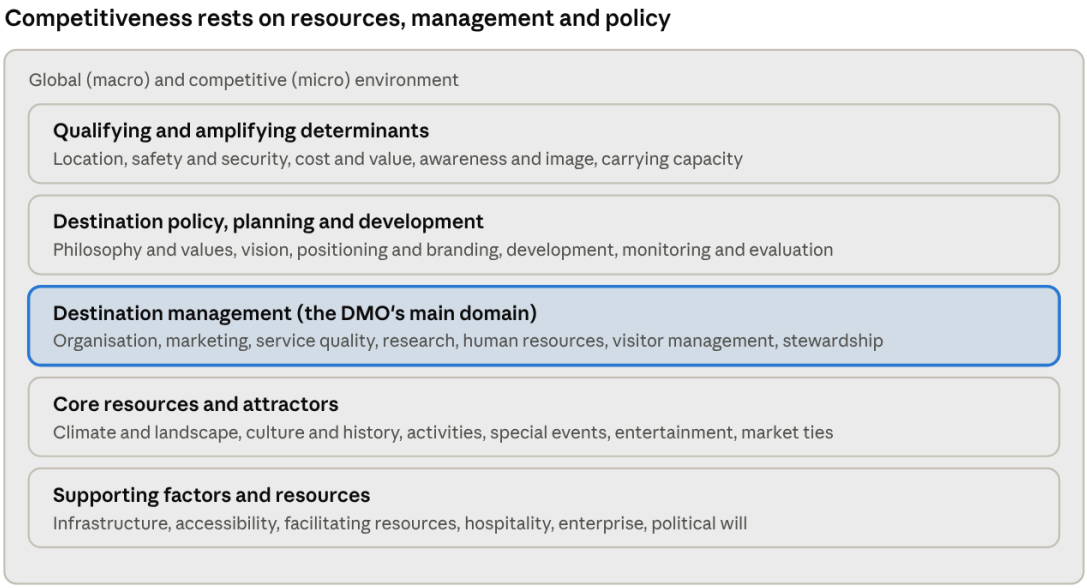


Figure 3 · Ritchie and Crouch's model, simplified

Source: simplified from Ritchie and Crouch (2003). The highlighted layer is the one most DMOs directly control.

Appendix D, Table 1: Case-study DMOs compared

Destination and body	Type	Funding	Formal powers	Sustainability tools	Outcomes
UK: VisitBritain	National public body	Government grant	Marketing and advice; no regulation	Regional dispersal campaigns, market data	Influence depends on national policy

Destination and body	Type	Funding	Formal powers	Sustainability tools	Outcomes
Copenhagen: Wonderful Copenhagen	Regional non-profit foundation	Mainly regional and city public funding	Convening and marketing; no regulation	Localhood strategy, CopenPay	Resident-centred agenda; limited control over hotel growth
Venice: city government	Municipality acting as manager	City budget, tourist tax, access fee	Regulation and pricing	Day-tripper access fee, tour group limit of 25, large cruise ships kept out of the lagoon	Revenue raised; deterrent effect disputed
Amsterdam: city government with its marketing partnership	City government plus public–private marketing body	City funds and partners	Regulation and taxation through the city	High tourist tax, demarketing, cap on overnight stays	Shift from promotion to management; risk of displacement
Saudi Arabia: Ministry of Tourism and Saudi Tourism Authority	National, state-led	State and Public Investment Fund	Strong: planning, investment, licensing	Visitor cap at Red Sea destination, development limits	Rapid volume growth; sustainability claims hard to verify
Dubai: Department of Economy and Tourism	City-state government department	State budget and Tourism Dirham fee	Licensing and regulation	Sustainability initiatives within growth targets	Growth-led

Destination and body	Type	Funding	Formal powers	Sustainability tools	Outcomes
Northern Pakistan: provincial tourism bodies and PTDC	Fragmented federal and provincial	Limited public budgets	Formal but weakly enforced	Few; ad hoc traffic and waste measures	Congestion, waste, Murree 2022 disaster

Appendix E, Table 2: Recommendations matrix

Recommendation	Challenge addressed	Evidence in the essay	Lead stakeholder
1. Fund and measure DMOs on value, wellbeing and carbon	Volume bias in metrics; leakage	TBL critique; Bhutan; Copenhagen	National and local government as funders
2. Formalise residents' role in governance	Loss of resident consent; overtourism	Doxey, G.V (1975); Ap (1992); Barcelona; Copenhagen	DMO boards and local authorities
3. Build data capability and platform partnerships	Platforms controlling visitor data; AI search	Smart tourism (Gretzel et al., 2015); CopenPay	DMOs with platforms and mobile operators
4. Give DMOs climate adaptation and crisis-resilience duties	Shocks absent from TALC; heat; conflict	UN Tourism (2026b); Scott, Hall and Gössling (2019); Gutic (2022)	National government and DMOs
5. Build local capacity and keep benefits local	Leakage; weak infrastructure in regional destinations	Northern Pakistan; Caribbean; Mowforth and Munt (2015)	Provincial government, DMOs, development partners